

ated with specific scenes. The animator is pretty much the “model” for the character and simulates body movements and facial expressions that he/she thinks will suit the character.

Upinder is an animator—“I am the actor behind the characters you see in an animated series!” From mimicry to lip-syncing dialogues, which are recorded as audio, his movements, which are recorded on video, are transposed using Softimage XSI onto a digital character’s movements. “Piggley, for example, is a naughty character—like me! I have to create movements according to the mood of the scene.”

His “workspace” is filled with sketches of a character-in-progress. Walk cycles, facial expressions, test sketches—Piggley’s movements have a hundred different variations on paper, before being “born” on Upin’s PC.

So what does Upin do all day? The first half hour involves chatting and e-mails. But soon after, Softimage XSI takes over as the sole mate, demanding complete and undivided attention. With eat-your-heart-out hardware specs (2 GB RAM, an Intel Pentium4 processor, a GeForce Quadro graphics card, an 80 GB hard disk, a 17-inch monitor), it’s not hard to decipher why!

“No distractions while at work. No MSN, no chat.” And music? “Rock, of course—Metallica, GnR, Linkin Park.” (“Music does distract us a bit, though,” he confesses.)

Caffeine keeps his system running... so lots and lots of coffee too!

After a hard day’s work, Upin and his friends head to Starcity in Mumbai for a movie. “Too few women in the animation industry, *yaar!*”

Out of Crest’s 350-odd employees, there are hardly 40 women. “I do go to a club and let my hair down once in a while.”

So are work hours always “official”? “Creativity is not time-bound. Although



My Favourite Things!

What makes these animators tick?

The Movies They Love

Dhaliwal: *Kal Ho Na Ho*, *Veer Zaara* (“only for the camerawork!”), *Iron Giant*, *Toy Story*, *Lord of the Rings*

Raj: *Monsters Inc.*, *Finding Nemo*, *Ice Age*, *American Pie*

Shilpa: *Pet Aliens* (a cartoon series), Disney films

Their Music Playlist

Dhaliwal: Metallica, GnR, Linkin’ Park

Raj: Pink Floyd

Their Software Weapons of Choice

Dhaliwal: Softimage XSI, Alias Maya (character animation)

Raj: Softimage XSI (BG)

Shilpa: Shake (2D) and Animo (3D) (compositing)

we do have work hours, a five-second shot could take several days and nights. Sometimes, I have worked straight weekends,” says Upin. “Not any more, though! Privileges of being a senior animator,” he adds dryly.

The Ambience Man

Once the characters have their, well, character, the team has to work on other elements such as texturing, colouring, lighting, and shadow effects, based on the scene. The background artiste, meanwhile, is working on the environment surrounding the character—from the furniture to the sky to overhanging vines.

Raj, a former background artiste and now team leader (“involved in top secret R&D activity!”) is in charge of creating the background images for Piggley and his friends. These are created part-by-part and then later merged.

And A Team Leader’s Workday?

Raj works on Softimage to create background images relevant to each scene. Raj builds the



Photographs Sherwin Crasto (Fotocorp)
Imaging Shaym Shriram

Upinder Dhaliwal, Animator